Nina the Nightingale and the Emperor's Song



A bedtime story for ages 4–7



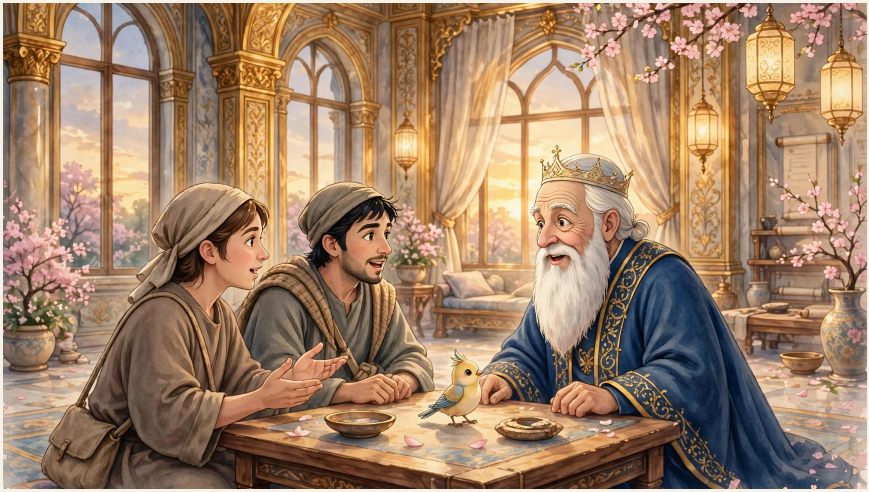
In a faraway land, beside the deep blue sea, stood a palace of pale marble, with gardens of pink blossom trees and a pond of floating lotus flowers. The Emperor had silk robes, golden dishes, and the loveliest garden anyone had ever seen.



Beyond the garden, in a quiet green forest, lived a small brown nightingale named Nina, with soft brown feathers, a pale cream belly, and bright dark eyes. Every evening at sunset, Nina sat on a low branch and sang.



Her song was soft and sweet, like water over smooth stones. The fishermen stopped to listen. The old woman gathering firewood stopped to listen. Even the moon seemed to pause and listen.



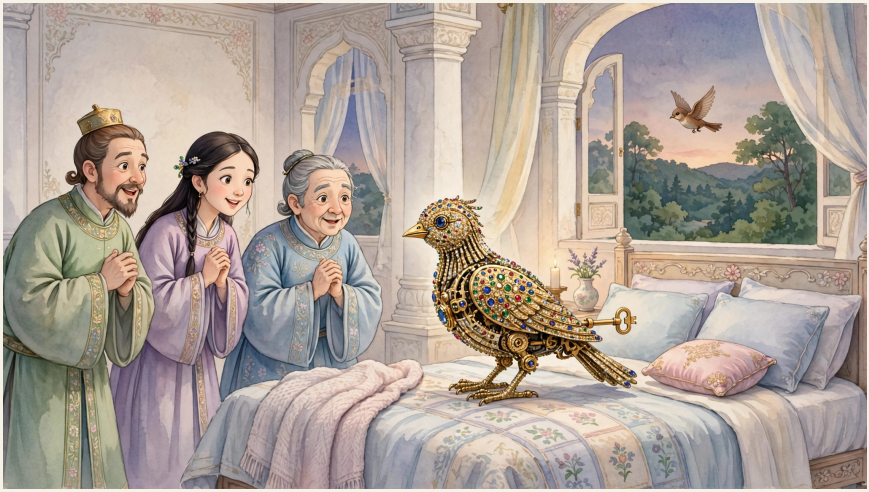
One day, travellers told the Emperor about the little bird. "Your Majesty," they said, "the finest thing in all your land is the nightingale's song, out in the forest." "A bird? In my own forest? Bring her to me at once."



The courtiers searched the forest all day, until they heard a small, sweet sound among the trees. There was Nina, perched on a branch, singing. "Little bird," said the chief courtier, "the Emperor wishes to hear you sing." "Then I will come," said Nina.



That evening, Nina sang in the golden hall. Her song drifted out of the windows. The Emperor closed his eyes and smiled. "That was the most beautiful thing I have ever heard," he said. "Little bird, stay and sing for me every day." So Nina stayed.



Then one morning, a gift arrived: a golden bird with a golden key in its side. When the key was turned, it sang a tinkling tune, the very same tune every time. "How wonderful!" cried the courtiers. "It sings without eating or sleeping!" It sat beside the Emperor's bed, and everyone forgot all about Nina.



Nina waited in the garden. No one came to listen. She flew back to her forest. But the golden bird could only sing its one tune, and one day the key would not turn any more. The music stopped. The Emperor grew sad, and he could not sleep.



One still night, the Emperor lay awake, and a sweet song drifted through the open window. It was Nina. She had come back, and she sang until the Emperor's eyes grew heavy. "You came back," whispered the Emperor, "even though I forgot you." "I sing because I love to sing," said Nina. "And because you needed a song."



The Emperor smiled, and fell into a deep, peaceful sleep. From that night on, Nina sang in the garden every evening, free among the blossom trees, where anyone could hear her. And every evening the Emperor opened his window wide.

Sleep now, little Nina.

The end. ■